

**KUWAIT**

Capital city: Kuwait
Area: 6,880 sq miles (17,820 sq km)
Population: 2,500,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 85%, other 15%
Government: Absolute monarchy with parliament
Currency: Kuwaiti dinar
Adult literacy rate: 83%
Life expectancy: 77 years
People per doctor: 526
Televisions: 491 per 1,000 people

BAHRAIN

Capital city: Manama
Area: 253 sq miles (655 sq km)
Population: 724,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 99%, other 1%
Government: Absolute monarchy
Currency: Bahraini dinar
Adult literacy rate: 89%
Life expectancy: 73 years
People per doctor: 1,000
Televisions: 472 per 1,000 people

QATAR

Capital city: Doha
Area: 4,416 sq miles (11,437 sq km)
Population: 610,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 95%, other 5%
Government: Absolute monarchy
Currency: Qatar riyal
Adult literacy rate: 82%
Life expectancy: 75 years
People per doctor: 769
Televisions: 404 per 1,000 people

KUWAIT

KUWAIT LIES AT THE NORTHERN end of the Persian Gulf. It is a small country, largely covered by sandy desert. Huge oil reserves have made Kuwait rich, and oil refining has become its chief industry. In 1990, at the start of the Gulf War, Kuwait was occupied by Iraq. It was liberated in 1991 by an international force.

KUWAIT'S WEALTH

Until the discovery of oil in the 1940s, Kuwait was a poor, underdeveloped country. The wealth gained by selling oil has transformed it into one of the most prosperous nations in the world. Its people enjoy a high standard of living, with free education, free health care and social services, and no income tax.



Kuwait's wealth is reflected in its impressive buildings, such as these water towers that dominate Kuwait's skyline.



POLLUTION

Kuwait suffered badly during its invasion by Iraq. Many of its oil wells were set on fire, causing enormous damage to the economy and the environment. A huge slick of oil spilled into the Gulf, poisoning the water and killing wildlife. Abandoned ammunition and unexploded mines litter the desert, and the cleaning up process continues today.

BAHRAIN

BAHRAIN IS MADE UP OF A SMALL GROUP of islands in the Persian Gulf. Little rain falls, so farming is only possible on irrigated, or watered, land. Bahrain was one of the first Arab states to discover oil in the 1930s. Its oil reserves are now running out.

PEARLING

As Bahrain's oil runs low, traditional industries, such as pearling, are once again growing in importance. The pearl season lasts from June to September. Divers descend on weighted ropes, equipped only with nose plugs, knives, and collecting bags. The most valuable pearls are bright white, tinged with pink.



A pearl taken from an oyster shell



LINKED ISLANDS

The main island of Bahrain is linked by a series of road causeways to the neighboring islands of Al Muharraq and Sitrah, and to the Saudi Arabian mainland, with which Bahrain has close relations. Bahrain island is only 30 miles (48 km) long, and the other islands are even smaller.

QATAR

QATAR IS A LONG PENINSULA of land jutting out into the Persian Gulf. It is mainly desert with a hot, dry climate. Oil production and refining form the basis of its economy. The government is trying to encourage the growth of fishing and agriculture to reduce the country's dependence on oil.

An Indian construction worker



WORKERS FROM ABROAD

In the 1940s, the smaller oil states such as Qatar and Kuwait encouraged workers from other parts of the Middle East, India, and Pakistan to work in their rapidly growing oil industries. Their own labor forces were simply too small to cope. Today, these migrant workers outnumber the local Qatari people.

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